

BACK ON THE TRAIL Neena Gupta, Raghubir Yadav and Jitendra Kumar in a still from *Panchayat*

Few can claim to be "India's most loved show" and get away with it. The Viral Fever's *Panchayat* is that rare show which does have the bragging rights. Packed with wry observations on everyday life and human behaviour in the hinterland and memorable characters, the Amazon Prime Video series has entered its fourth season, an incredible feat in itself. Actor Neena Gupta credits the writing of Chandan Kumar and the work put in by director Deepak Kumar Mishra. "Season after season, they do something special. I wait for the script. I don't know how they do it," she says. "We don't need to improvise; *sab kuchh milta hai* [everything's there in the script itself]." She further attributes apt casting for the show's success, which has seen actors become synonymous with their parts, with some even featuring in viral memes (type Binod, Bhushan and Bam Bahadur in Google and get ready for laughs).

One such character to have struck a chord is the mean confrontational machine that's Kranti Devi, played by the talented Sunita Rajwar. "Wherever you are from, people love *Panchayat* because you can watch it with your family," she says.

"*Saral hai. Smart banne ki koshish nahin hai* [It's simple. They don't try to be oversmart]. They show things with respect," adds Gupta on the TVF formula that has seen it generate hit shows like *Kota Factory*, *The Aspirants* and *Pitchers*.

Panchayat's fourth run puts the women in the spotlight: Rinki ki Mummy a.k.a. Manju Devi (Gupta) and Kranti Devi battle it out in the elections. Further proof of the ladies' growing stature are the promotional posters where Manju brandishes her election symbol, the gourd, while Kranti holds the pressure cooker.

"This time, I have become interested in the elections and in doing things," says Gupta. "The seed was sown in the earlier seasons when characters have asked why I don't do anything." If Manju Devi takes more initiative in the quest to retain her seat, Kranti is a rookie largely following the questionable footsteps of her husband, the ever-entertaining Bhushan a.k.a. Banrakas (Durgesh Kumar). "I don't know any better," says Rajwar of her character. "For the first time, she is getting importance. She is going to the *vidhayak*'s house, who in turn is playing the bigger game as he knows we are upset with Pradhaan-ji and company. But most of the major planning is done by the three [Bhushan, Binod and Madhav]."

> *Panchayat*'s fourth run sees Neena Gupta and Sunita Rajwar's characters battle it out in the elections

It's one thing to be part of pop culture conversations, another to catalyse societal change. Such is the show's influence that the ministry of panchayati raj recently roped in members of the cast to shoot small skits where Gupta's Manju Devi is the elected representative calling the shots, and not her husband. "There are seats where women win but it's the husbands who run the show," says Gupta. "But I have decided I will do this. To be part of an initiative that encourages and inspires other women is special."